

Wish I Quit Playing Sports At 18

Channel: Onem · Published: Sep 11, 2026 · Watch: <https://www.youtube.com/shorts/q5eFHBC3KAo> Source: full transcript

Executive Summary

Mid-run, the speaker reflects on a lingering football knee injury and argues that while sport builds valuable life skills, competitive play past age 18-19 does the body more harm than good — echoing his late father's warning that "your body is a battery."

Contents

- 🦵 The Knee Injury That Sparked the Reflection
- ✅ What Sport Did Give Him
- 💀 His Father's Warning: "Your Body Is a Battery"
- 😞 The Meaningless Game That Caused the Injury
- 🏆 What He Would Do Differently

🦵 The Knee Injury That Sparked the Reflection 0:00

- At the start of every run he must stop to stretch and massage one knee before he can continue
 - The knee is an old football injury that requires a warm-up ritual every single time
 - He notes it had already loosened up about 20 seconds after stretching — "My knee feels amazing. It's loosened up" — but the fact it needs that every time is the point

✅ What Sport Did Give Him 0:22

- He is **100% grateful** for his football career and does not dismiss it entirely
- Benefits he credits to his sporting background:
 - Transferable physical literacy — he moves differently to other people
 - Can pick up any new sport within about **10 minutes** and be "pretty good at it"
 - Mental resilience — when life gets hard he recalls games where his team was losing and that makes difficulties feel easier
 - Memories from the game itself
- He distinguishes these life-skill benefits from the football skills themselves, calling the sport-specific skills "meaningless now"

💀 His Father's Warning: "Your Body Is a Battery" 1:31

- His father died of cancer; on his deathbed at home he gave this direct advice: **"Quit playing sport, quit playing football"**
 - He allowed for light casual activity: "If you do a little bit of paddle or tennis casually, fair enough"
 - His core belief: "It's not good for your body"
- The father's own story as evidence:
 - Played football until he was **47 or 48 years old**
 - Later moved to Barcelona and continued playing even while living with cancer for several years
 - Concluded: "I don't think it did me any favors"
- The "battery" framework:
 - The body has a finite energy reserve, like a battery
 - Sustained competitive sport drains that battery over the years and burns it out
- The speaker applies this to his own knee:
 - That one knee injury could be "the difference between me playing with my kids in 10 years time or not"
 - He may need surgery or further intervention because of it

"Your body is a battery" — the speaker's father, reflecting on a lifetime of sport while dying of cancer.

The Meaningless Game That Caused the Injury 2:18

- The knee injury happened when he was around **22 or 23 years old**
- Context of the game that caused it:
 - A random Saturday
 - Raining
 - Playing for **no money**
 - Described as a "meaningless game"
- He was already injured going into it, but the manager said "We need you" and he went back on and played anyway
- Looking back, he asks simply: "What was I doing?" and "Why was I doing that?"
 - The combination of no financial reward, no career progression, and a pre-existing injury makes the decision seem indefensible in hindsight

What He Would Do Differently 2:40

- His revised life plan if he could go back:
 - Play sport when young to **build a foundation** of physical literacy and mental toughness
 - Stop competitive sport at around **18 or 19** — the moment a coach or authority figure confirmed he would not become a professional footballer
 - His exact hypothetical response at that point: "Okay, I'm never going to play again"

- What he would pivot to instead:
 - Full commitment to **weights and aesthetics**
 - "Aesthetic performance" — training focused on how you look and how your body functions in daily life
 - Activities that "actually benefit you in day-to-day life"
- His implicit argument: competitive recreational sport past the age where a professional career is possible offers diminishing returns and meaningful injury risk for zero financial or career upside